The D2C store leak audit: 30 checks before you spend more on ads

Most stores lose revenue in the same places. Tick each check your store passes today. The ones you cannot tick are where your ad spend is leaking.

How to score it. 26 to 30 ticks: your store is in good shape; look at ads and retention next. 18 to 25: fix the checkout and product page items first. Under 18: start with tracking, because the other numbers cannot be trusted yet.

1. Tracking you can trust

If the numbers are wrong, every other decision is a guess.

- [ ] Purchases in GA4 roughly match orders in Shopify for the same week
- [ ] Every paid link carries UTM tags, so you can see which campaign drove which order
- [ ] The Meta pixel and Conversions API record each purchase once, not twice
- [ ] You report revenue after returns and refunds, not just gross sales

2. Landing and product page

- [ ] Price, the main benefit and a delivery estimate are visible without scrolling on a phone
- [ ] Reviews or a star rating sit near the price, not only at the bottom of the page
- [ ] Size, fit or variant guidance is one tap away
- [ ] Shipping cost or the free-shipping threshold is shown before the cart
- [ ] The return or exchange policy is one tap away
- [ ] Add to cart stays visible (sticky) as the shopper scrolls on mobile
- [ ] Product images load quickly on a mobile connection

3. Cart

- [ ] The cart shows the full total including shipping before checkout
- [ ] Quantity and variant can be changed without leaving the cart
- [ ] Any upsell in the cart is relevant and does not push the shopper away from checkout
- [ ] Discount code field does not dominate the cart and send people off to search for codes

4. Checkout

Baymard Institute puts average cart abandonment at 70.22%; unexpected extra costs are among the most common reasons shoppers give.

- [ ] Guest checkout is available; no forced account creation

- [ ] Express payment is offered: Shop Pay, Apple Pay or Google Pay
- [ ] No new cost appears at the last step
- [ ] Only the fields you really need are asked for
- [ ] Trust signals (secure payment, returns) sit close to the pay button
- [ ] A delivery date or window is shown before payment

5. Speed

- [ ] You have tested a product page on pagespeed.web.dev (mobile) in the last month
- [ ] Apps you no longer use are uninstalled and their leftover code removed
- [ ] Large images are compressed and below-the-fold images load lazily

6. Payments, delivery and returns

- [ ] Buy now, pay later (Afterpay, Klarna, Clearpay or Affirm) is offered only where its fee still leaves margin
- [ ] Delivery promises on the product page match what your carrier actually achieves
- [ ] The returns process is simple to start online, and you track the main return reasons

7. After the first order

- [ ] The order confirmation email does more than show a receipt
- [ ] A review request goes out once the customer has had time to use the product
- [ ] A repeat-purchase or replenishment email is set up for your best repeat product

Want a second pair of eyes?

Comment **AUDIT** on any @marginwise.in post or send your store link by DM. We send back a free 2-minute video teardown within one working day. Or book a free 30-minute call at **marginwise.in**.

Sources: Baymard Institute, cart abandonment rate (average of 50 studies) and checkout usability research. This checklist is a starting point; the right order of fixes depends on your traffic and margins.